

65 of them U.S. merchantmen or whalers. He burned most of the ships, but not before removing their crews, whom he placed aboard neutral ships or ashore in neutral ports. At any given time, up to a dozen Union ships were hunting the *Alabama*. Huge crowds came to see the famous ship when she anchored in Cape Town in August 1863. But the days of this raider were doomed to be short. On June 11, 1864, the *Alabama* sought haven in Cherbourg, France. After 22 months, mostly spent at sea, both crew and ship were in need of rest and repair. Three days later, the sloop-of-war USS *Kearsarge* appeared outside the harbor. Her commander, Captain John Winslow, had been a shipmate of Semmes when they were both young.